Where do you find your inspiration and what is your process when beginning a project?

There are a couple different ways to start, but I have inspiration stockpiled. I have a lifetime of absorbing artwork, other graphic design, history, movies, walking down the street—everything is fodder. The fodder's over here at one side of the brain, and on the other side are the people in the brief, and you're really looking and listening to your clients based on where they've been and where they're going, and then you begin to try to create a language and a basis for them to get where they're going, and that has to do with who they think their audience is, what their problems have been in the past, and how much they want to make a statement about who they are to be recognized and then lead them to how to do that, and it's a little bit of trial and error.

It's sort of like being in a lab. We make a series of experiments that are called phase one, and that's taking the input they gave us and making some demonstration that demonstrates type faces, color palettes, ideas, themes and motifs, and ways of seeing if a bunch of things are recognizable as one thing. It's a little bit like a scientific experiment. How much do you recognize this thing over here? Three are in a row, one looks weird. Okay, what's wrong with that? We have to figure that out and fix it. Or they all look alike, but if they look too much alike and they want to differentiate the plays, then you resolve those issues in phase two, so you can make corrections and accommodations.



Paula Scher - Bring in 'da Noise / Bring in 'da Funk

Then, in the third phase, you're teaching them how to work with it and figuring out how they're going execute it. That's the hardest phase of all, because sometimes I set up in-house art departments, so I'll find other people to do some of this work for us. Mostly we do the first launch and then we try to staff it, and that person would probably work with us pretty closely in the first six months to a year until they can really take it over.